'Active wheelchairs can make a world of difference'

Rehabilitation camp for persons with spinal injuries held

Staff Reporter

VISAKHAPATNAM: Active wheelchairs are much superior to passive wheelchairs and they can make a world of difference in the lives of persons living with spinal injuries. This was demonstrated by Rajiv Virat from Indian Spinal Injuries Centre and Jonathan from Empowering Spinal Cord Injured Persons, USA, at the third Annual Active Rehabilitation Camp here on Monday. The two-day camp is being organised by The Ability People, and the idea is to promote the concept of active wheelchair and train the persons with disability on how to use it.

Performing wheelies and clearing obstacles at will on his wheelchair, Rajiv cleared the myth that persons living with spinal disorders are dependents. He pointed out that a normal passive wheelchair weighs over 30 kg., whereas an active one would weigh between 4 kg. and 12 kg. "The propelling, mobility and manoeuvrability is much easier in the active version. By shifting to an active wheel chair one can create a world of possibilities," he said.

An under-14 national football player, multiple sclerosis has forced Rajiv to a wheelchair, but it has not been able to dent his spirits. Because of his wheelchair skills he has transformed himself from a dependent user to an independent leader. He now trains doctors, patients and therapists at the centre and is a globetrotter.

Over 340 people with different kinds of spinal injuries are attending the two-day camp and The Ability People is distributing about 11 active wheelchairs.

'Imported'

"Active wheelchairs are not manufactured in India, they are imported. The government should think of subsidising the cost," said Dr. Kiran of Krushi Orthopaedic Welfare Society.

The doctor also pointed out that timely spine de-compressive surgery can completely heal or reduce the injury level to a great extent.

Talking to the patients, Jonathan urged them to keep the body weight in control. Adding further, Dr. Surya Prakash Rao, a challenged person himself, said, "The digestive power reduces to an extent, and this calls for a balanced diet. Increase in weight can create further problems." Motivating the differently-abled, Dilip Patro of The Ability People said, "If you think life is all about the disability- then it is going to be hell for you. On a different note if you think that there is much more beyond it- then life is going to be sweet and nice." The Commissioner of Police J. Purnachandra Rao and Commissioner of GVMC B. Ramanjaneyulu visited the camp. While Purnachandra Rao announced a contribution of Rs. 50,000 from his and the salary of his officers for the procurement of active wheelchairs for the people who cannot afford, Mr. Ramanjaneyulu announced a contribution of Rs. 50,000 from GVMC.



INTERACTIVE: *Police Commissioner J. Purnachandra Rao having a word with one of the beneficiaries of a rehabilitation camp organised by The Ability People in Visakhapatnam on Monday.*

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